On the one hand, Virupaksha Temple, their state temple, was run by followers of Adi Shankara, who, in the eighth century, had boosted Advaita Vedanta—a non-dualistic interpretation of Vedanta—along with a renunciatory monasticism led by mathas. Cannibhatta, a fourteenth-century conservative logician in the Vijayanagar court, wrote a treatise defending Advaita Vedanta, 'the philosophy officially embraced by the Vijayanagar court'.[24] On the other hand, the state also patronized the opposing view of Dvaita Vedanta—a dualistic interpretation of Vedanta. This was taught by Vyasatirtha (1460–1539), a scholar, poet, devotional singer, head of the Madhava Brahmin monastic sect and *rajguru* to Krishnadevaraya himself.

One of Vyasatirtha's disciples was Purandara Dasa (1484–1564), a wealthy jewellery trader who had given away all his wealth to become a devotee of Lord Krishna. He attained great fame as a Bhakti saint and singer of devotional melodies. He was also a scholar of music, and his classical compositions laid the foundations of what became Carnatic music. In fact, so great was his influence that he's widely regarded as the father of Carnatic music. Some call him an avatar of the celestial singer Narada. He spent his later years in Vijayanagar, composing and singing devotional songs to Lord Vitthala. He lived by the scenic river in an open pillared pavilion, Purandara Dasa Mantapa, near which an annual music festival now celebrates his legacy.

This religious substrate—renunciatory monasticism plus mystical devotionalism—was part of a larger shift that had occurred in Hinduism. It helps explain why there is so little erotica on temple walls in Vijayanagar. I search thousands of relief sculptures and statues and find less than ten copulating couples—remains of a dying trend, marginal in placement and import. In fact, the Hinduism and temple art of Vijayanagar were well on their way to the far more insipid and puritanical strains of Hinduism and temple art that Hindus identify with today. These strains had been amplified by Adi Shankara and Bhakti, long before the invasions of Mahmud of Ghazni from 1000 CE. They would get reinforced by their contact with the Sunni, Shia and Sufi Islams that came from the north-west, and later with Victorian Britain (see 'The Enigma of Khajuraho' for a discussion on why erotic art disappeared from temple walls across India).